

# **NFL Innovation HUB**

Establishing Formal Governance & Structure

Executive Steering Committee

January 2026

# Executive Summary: Critical Need for Governance

## THE PROBLEM

Projects entering & exiting HUB without formal approval gates, creating resource churn and burning through allocated hours with limited visibility

## THE IMPACT

12+ projects tracked in past 12 months with unclear scope, roles, and boundaries • Significant NFL time invested with inconsistent outcomes

## THE SOLUTION

### Formalize the 3-Model Program Structure

Innovation Challenges • Co-Create Programs • Operationalization & Change Management

### Implement Mandatory Intake & Approval Process

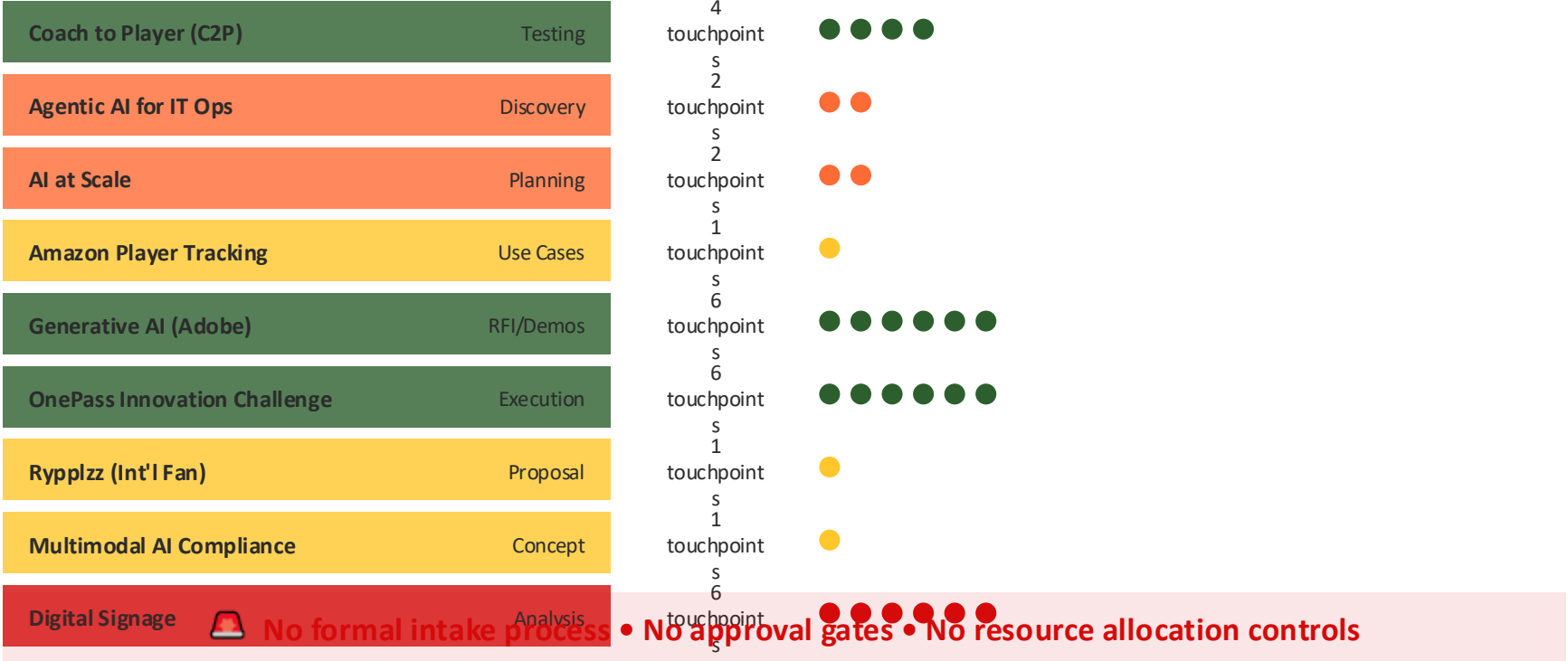
Stage gates with NFL stakeholder sign-off before resource allocation

### Establish Clear Roles & Responsibilities

NFL approves Intake/prioritization • NOVATE manages execution • Defined boundaries with vendors

# The Problem: Uncontrolled Project Churn

12 Months of Project Activity (Jan 2025 - Jan 2026)



# The Impact: Resource Allocation Without Visibility

**12+**

**Projects Tracked**

*in past 12 months*

**4.3**

**Avg Touchpoints**

*per project*

**Unknown**

**Resource Utilization**

*no tracking mechanism*

**High**

**NFL Stakeholder Time**

*inconsistent engagement*

## CONSEQUENCES

- **Partial Visibility**  
Projects enter HUB through informal channels without documented scope or success criteria
- **Limited NFL Participation**  
Unclear stakeholder engagement leads to misaligned expectations and delayed decisions
- **Unclear Vendor Boundaries**  
No defined protocols for when/how to engage NFL vendors creates confusion and potential conflicts
- **Resource Burn**  
NOVATE hours consumed on undefined scope without strategic prioritization

# Root Cause: Missing Governance Framework

*The 2025 Program Design exists but is not being enforced*

| DESIGNED STRUCTURE                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   | CURRENT REALITY                                                                                                                                                                                          | REQUIRED ACTIONS                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <p>3-Model Program:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Innovation Challenges</li><li>• Co-Create Programs</li><li>• Operationalization</li></ul> <p>Stage Gate Process:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Intake → Concept → Business Case → MVP → ROI → Grow</li></ul> <p>Clear Governance:</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"><li>• Exec Steering Committee</li><li>• Program Execution Committee</li><li>• NFL approvals required</li></ul> | <p>Projects bypass intake</p> <p>No formal approval process</p> <p>Unclear which model applies</p> <p>Stage gates not enforced</p> <p>Resource allocation ad hoc</p> <p>Limited executive visibility</p> | <p>Mandate intake process</p> <p>Activate stage gates</p> <p>Define approval authority</p> <p>Establish project classification</p> <p>Implement tracking system</p> <p>Monthly governance reviews</p> |

# The Designed Structure: 3-Model Program

*2025 Program Design defines three engagement models - we need to enforce them*

## MODEL 1: NFL Innovation Challenges

Curated end-to-end pipeline for sourcing, testing, and scaling high-impact innovations. Multi-phase process with league stakeholder champions. Co-funded by league departments.

## MODEL 2: NFL Co-Create Program

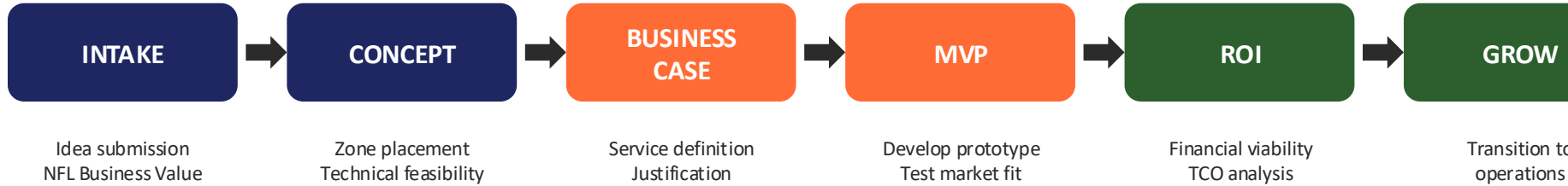
Partner-driven innovation with sponsors and approved partners. Includes Sponsored POC Track and Partner-Funded Co-Create. All sponsor communications coordinated with NFL Sponsorship.

## MODEL 3: Operationalization & Change Management

Apply HUB infrastructure to internal priorities through R&D, prototyping, and rapid launch capabilities. Internal tech integrations and POCs impacting multiple departments.

# Stage Gate Process: Required Approvals

*Every project must progress through defined stages with NFL approval*



## APPROVAL AUTHORITY AT EACH GATE

**Stage 1-2 (Intake/Concept):** Program Execution Committee review • NFL sponsor identified

**Stage 3 (Business Case):** SVP approval required • Resource allocation approved

**Stage 4-5 (MVP/ROI):** Quarterly reviews with Program Execution Committee

**Stage 6 (Grow):** Executive Steering Committee approval for operationalization

# Governance Structure: Decision Rights

## Executive Steering Committee

*EVPs • Strategic direction • Annual priorities*

## Program Execution Committee

*SVPs from IT, Player Health & Safety, Football Ops, Media, Data & Analytics, Finance, Sponsorship*

## Innovation Tech Advisory Committee

*NFL Technical Working Group • Subject matter experts • Technical evaluation*

**Innovation HUB PMO (NOVATE) - Intake, Prioritization & Program Management**

# Roles & Responsibilities: Clear Boundaries

## NFL RESPONSIBILITIES

- Approve project intake and prioritization
- Provide internal stakeholder and tech access
- Align funding and timelines via governance cadence
- Stage gate approvals at Business Case, MVP, and Grow phases
- Define success criteria and measurement

## NOVATE RESPONSIBILITIES

- Program Director + Ops Analyst (Core team)
- Intake & blueprinting management
- R&D delivery via Innovation Pods and NIN Partner Network
- Internal knowledge hub (EVERGAME + Sentrais)
- All projects tagged and tracked by zone, model, phase

# Vendor Engagement: Defined Protocols

*Clear boundaries for when and how to engage with NFL vendors*

## SCENARIO 1: Innovation Challenge - External Vendors

NOVATE sources, evaluates, and manages external vendors. NFL approves finalists. No engagement with existing NFL vendors unless explicitly approved by NFL leadership.

## SCENARIO 2: Co-Create - Sponsor/Partner Vendors

All sponsor communications coordinated with NFL Sponsorship. Partner-funded POCs require Steering Committee approval. RACI matrix defines engagement boundaries upfront.

## SCENARIO 3: Operationalization - Existing NFL Vendors

NOVATE acts as R&D resource to IT/BRM functions. NFL retains all vendor relationships. NOVATE provides technical blueprints and recommendations only - no direct vendor engagement without NFL approval.

**KEY PRINCIPLE:** NFL retains all decision-making authority on vendor relationships. NOVATE provides evaluation framework and recommendations. All vendor engagements require documented NFL approval before initiation.

# Mandatory Intake Process

*All projects must enter through formal intake - no exceptions*



# Tracking & Visibility: Sentrais Integration

*Every project tagged and tracked in real-time*

**TAGGING TAXONOMY: [ZONE]-[MODEL]-[NIN PHASE]-[STATUS]**

*Example: TRANSFORMATION-CHALLENGE-P3-ACTIVE*

## ZONES

Incubation  
Transformation  
Performance  
Productivity

## MODELS

Challenge  
Co-Create  
Operationalization

## NIN PHASES

P1: Discovery  
P2: Blueprinting  
P3: Innovation  
P4: Pilot  
P5: Operationalization  
P6: Iteration

**Monthly Dashboard Reviews with Program Execution Committee**

# Resource Management: Defined Allocation

*Projects are outcome-bound with defined runway and resourcing*

## Each Project Defines:

**Estimated Hours:** Range-based allocation (e.g., 40-60 hrs for Discovery phase)

**Timeline:** Defined runway with milestones and decision points

**Scope:** Clear deliverables and success criteria documented upfront

**Stop Conditions:** Criteria for project pause, pivot, or termination

**ROI Metrics:** Defined success measures for NFL and partners

**Avoiding Churn: No project moves forward without approved scope, timeline, and resource allocation**

# Implementation Roadmap

## *60-Day Plan to Formalize Governance*

### **IMMEDIATE** **(Week 1-2)**

1. Steering Committee approval of governance framework
2. Communicate new intake requirements to all stakeholders
3. Audit all current projects and classify by model
4. Retroactively document scope for active projects

### **SHORT-TERM** **(Week 3-4)**

1. Implement intake form and approval workflow
2. Establish monthly governance review cadence
3. Deploy Sentrais tagging for all projects
4. Create vendor engagement protocol documentation

### **SUSTAINED** **(Week 5-8)**

1. First monthly dashboard review
2. Enforce stage gate approvals on all new projects
3. Measure resource utilization and adjust
4. Continuous improvement based on feedback

# Success Metrics: Measuring Governance Impact

*How we'll know the governance framework is working*

**100%**

## **Intake Compliance**

All new projects enter through formal intake process

**Monthly**

## **Dashboard Reviews**

Program Exec Committee receives project status updates

**Full**

## **Project Visibility**

Real-time tracking of all HUB projects in Sentrais

**≥75%**

## **Resource Efficiency**

NOVATE hours allocated to approved, scoped projects

**Clear**

## **Vendor Boundaries**

Documented protocols followed on all engagements

**Defined**

## **Success Criteria**

Every project has measurable outcomes

# Decision Required

Approve formalized governance framework  
and mandatory intake process

## **Without formal governance:**

- Project churn will continue unabated
- Resource allocation remains uncontrolled
- NFL stakeholder time continues to be under-utilized
- HUB value proposition becomes unclear

# Next Steps

## 1. Steering Committee Approval

Formal approval of governance framework and intake process

## 2. Stakeholder Communication

Announce new requirements to all NFL departments and partners

## 3. Current Project Audit

Classify all active projects and retroactively document scope

## 4. Intake System Launch

Deploy intake form, approval workflow, and Sentrais tracking

## 5. First Governance Review

Schedule monthly dashboard review with Program Execution Committee



# Questions & Discussion

Let's formalize the structure that  
delivers measurable innovation outcomes